Where to Measure Next? Evaluating Feedback-Driven Region Selection for Spatial Transcriptomics

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Abstract

Spatial transcriptomics is costly, so many studies profile only selected regions of a section, and recent methods choose each next region from expression already measured. A recent benchmark of active spot selection for training predictors across patients reported inconsistent gains over random sampling; we ask instead whether, within a slide, measured feedback improves selection over a fixed design matched to the objective. We built a retrospective simulator from 22 human HEST-1k slides (18 studies, four tissues), fixed the image encoder and imputer, registered four analysis stages in timestamped commits before running them, and drew inference at the study level. Each feedback policy was compared with a non-adaptive design chosen on held-out studies and with itself fed uninformative values. **RQ1:** for whole-section reconstruction, a policy targeting the imputer's error was below the fixed design at every budget up to 10%, by up to 0.092 Pearson correlation and significantly at 0.5 and 1%, both on its own unprofiled regions and on a common held-out set. **RQ2:** for capturing heterogeneous regions, the registered policy did not detectably beat a design chosen for detection, and a diversity sampler that uses no feedback did about as well; with its settings chosen on the other studies, the same policy beat the design by 0.016 to 0.049 recall at 2–10%, but not detectably the diversity sampler. **RQ3:** spending half or more of the budget on a fixed design and the rest on feedback never beat that design; from 2% upward every hybrid was within 0.007 correlation and 0.006 recall of it, a null with at least 80% power to detect gains of 0.02 and 0.03 at 2–10%. **RQ4** (exploratory): batches of five neither eroded nor established a detection advantage. With 300 μm tiles no feedback policy beat the fixed design, a null that could miss gains below about 0.04 to 0.12. Within simulated budgets, one imputer, and computational endpoints, the feedback policies we tested lost to a well-chosen fixed design for reconstruction, where neither positive control showed that a gain could be detected; for detection, a tuned feedback policy beat the registered fixed designs but not detectably a diversity design. Adaptive acquisition methods should be benchmarked against the strongest objective-matched fixed designs, against themselves without informative feedback, and with settings chosen on held-out data.

1 Introduction

Spatial transcriptomics measures gene expression without dissociating tissue, so expression can be read in its histological context (Ståhl et al., 2016; Rao et al., 2021; Moses & Pachter, 2022). Whole-transcriptome assays remain costly, and region-of-interest platforms such as GeoMx DSP (Merritt et al., 2020) profile only selected regions of a section. Expression elsewhere can be predicted from the co-registered hematoxylin and eosin (H&E) image (Xie et al., 2023; Jaume et al., 2024). Which regions are measured therefore determines both how well the unmeasured tissue can be reconstructed and whether distinct tissue compartments are measured at all.

Choosing regions is an experimental-design problem, and recent methods solve it sequentially. SOFisher (Li et al., 2026) uses reinforcement learning to move fields of view toward regions enriched for a target signal, and SCR^2-ST (Zhu et al., 2026a) learns where to sample spots to build training sets for expression prediction. S2-omics (Yuan et al., 2025) takes the opposite approach and selects regions from histology alone, before any

measurement. The appeal of sequential selection follows active learning (Settles, 2009): each measurement can inform the next. Its cost is a measurement turnaround between choices. A recent benchmark of active spot selection for training expression predictors found inconsistent gains over random sampling at small budgets (Zhu et al., 2026b), but addressed a different decision (Section 2). We are not aware of an evaluation that compares feedback-driven region selection within a slide against fixed designs, whose selections do not depend on measured values, matched to the objective while ablating the measured feedback itself.

Theory gives different expectations for different goals. For reconstructing a Gaussian-process field with a known kernel, posterior variance does not depend on the observed values, so a design fixed before any measurement is as good as a sequential one; when the model's parameters are uncertain, sequential designs can do better (Krause et al., 2008). Imputers learned from images are not Gaussian processes with known kernels, so for reconstruction the question is empirical. Finding regions defined by their expression is closer to active search, in which each choice exploits the labels already observed to locate further targets (Garnett et al., 2012).

Beating random selection does not show that feedback helps, because a policy can win through its selection rule alone. An evaluation that can separate these cases needs four features. The baseline must be a design that could be chosen before the target slide is profiled, because selecting the best design on the evaluation data biases the comparison (Varma & Simon, 2006; Cawley & Talbot, 2010). Generalisation must be assessed across studies, not within them (Bernau et al., 2014), with slides from one study treated as dependent (Field & Welsh, 2007). The contribution of feedback must be isolated by giving the same policy uninformative values, in the spirit of permutation tests for learning algorithms (Ojala & Garriga, 2010). Finally, null results need positive controls and power analysis to be interpretable (Altman & Bland, 1995).

We built such an evaluation and asked four questions. **RQ1**: does conditioning region selection on measured expression improve whole-section reconstruction over a feasible non-adaptive design? **RQ2**: does it improve the capture of molecularly heterogeneous regions? **RQ3**: does feedback add to a strong fixed design when it allocates only the remainder of the budget? **RQ4**, an exploratory stress test: does a detection advantage persist when measurements arrive in batches? Across four registered stages, no feedback policy beat a well-chosen fixed design for reconstruction, which was significantly better at small budgets even when all policies were scored on the same held-out regions. For detection, the registered policy did not beat a design chosen for detection, but a version tuned on other studies did, modestly, though not detectably better than a diversity sampler that uses no feedback. We contribute (i) a reproducible simulator on 22 human slides from 18 studies with feasible, objective-matched baselines, feedback ablations, and study-level inference; (ii) a registered negative result for reconstruction and a qualified positive result for detection, made interpretable by positive controls and minimum detectable effects; and (iii) an account of the result: the imputer's uncertainty depends only on where regions are profiled, so feedback can aid reconstruction only through its predictions, and for detection a diversity sampler without feedback finds heterogeneous regions about as well as the untuned policy.

2 Related work

Expression from histology. Expression has been predicted from H&E by contrastive retrieval (Xie et al., 2023), flow matching over spatial neighbourhoods (Huang et al., 2025), diffusion (Zhu et al., 2025), and autoregressive generation (Ouyang et al., 2025), and benchmarked on HEST-1k (Jaume et al., 2024). These methods take the measured regions as given. We hold the predictor fixed and vary only the regions it receives.

Choosing what to measure. Pool-based active learning selects queries by uncertainty (Lewis & Gale, 1994), expected error reduction (Roy & McCallum, 2001), or coverage of the input space (Sener & Savarese, 2018). Sensor placement offers the matching non-adaptive designs: variance- and mutual-information-greedy selection, which are near-optimal for Gaussian-process reconstruction (Krause et al., 2008). Adaptive submodularity extends such guarantees to greedy policies that condition on observations (Golovin & Krause, 2011), and active search addresses the related goal of collecting positives (Garnett et al., 2012). In batch acquisition, the members of a batch are chosen without each other's labels (Kirsch et al., 2019), and global

optimisation commonly begins with a space-filling design before switching to adaptive queries (Jones et al., 1998). Active feature acquisition casts measurement as a sequential policy (Yin et al., 2020).

Design in spatial omics. Gene-panel selectors fix which genes to measure (Covert et al., 2023; Lu et al., 2026). Region selectors range from image-based rankers such as SpatialFinder, which score regions from H&E before any expression is measured (Xu et al., 2026), and histology-based heterogeneity selection (Yuan et al., 2025) to sequential reinforcement-learning samplers (Li et al., 2026; Zhu et al., 2026a). Our evaluation includes reimplementations of these objectives and a native run of SOFisher. The closest evaluation is a retrospective benchmark of active spot selection on breast and skin cancer cohorts (Zhu et al., 2026b), which compared uncertainty- and diversity-based strategies with random sampling and found that active strategies did not consistently win at small budgets. Its question differs from ours in three ways. It selects spots to train a morphology-to-expression predictor that is evaluated on held-out patients, whereas we select regions within a slide for a fixed imputer. Its baseline is random sampling, whereas ours are non-adaptive designs chosen for each objective. It compares selection strategies, whereas we hold each strategy fixed and remove the information in the measured values.

3 Methods

3.1 Acquisition simulator

A slide is a set of regions, each with an image embedding, spatial coordinates, and measured expression. A policy reveals regions one at a time until a budget, a fixed fraction of the slide's regions, is spent; each revealed region exposes its measured expression to the policy. The simulator is retrospective, as in pool-based active-learning evaluation (Settles, 2009): every region has been measured, so any selection can be scored against ground truth. For RQ4, regions are revealed in rounds, and within a round the policy can use only measurements available at its start. Budgets range from 0.5% of regions (9 to 45 regions depending on slide size, comparable to ROI-based profiling) to 20%.

3.2 Slides and preprocessing

We used 22 human HEST-1k slides (Jaume et al., 2024) from prostate (6), kidney (4), lung (6), and colon (6), of which 7 are Visium HD (de Oliveira et al., 2025) and 15 standard Visium (Ståhl et al., 2016) (Appendix A). The tissues are the four used to evaluate the image-based ranker we compare against (Xu et al., 2026). Selection rules were fixed before any result on these slides: human tissue, whole-transcriptome assay, at least 1,000 spots under tissue, a source image of at most 0.6 μm/px so that image patches are not substantially upsampled, one slide per specimen, and at most two slides per study. The slides come from 18 studies, which serve as the independent units of inference.

A region is one native spot, the unit at which HEST provides both expression and an image patch. Visium spots are 55 μm wide on a 100 μm pitch. HEST distributes Visium HD data as 128 μm square pseudo-spots pooled from 16 μm bins, the default of its Visium HD reader,[1] so an HD region covers about seven times the area of a Visium spot. Slides contain 1,766 to 9,080 regions. Each region's image input is the HEST 224 px patch at 0.5 μm/px (Jaume et al., 2024), embedded with UNI2-h, a later release of the pathology foundation model UNI (Chen et al., 2024),[2] used frozen. Following the HEST benchmark, expression is log1p-transformed and genes detected in fewer than 10% of regions are removed (Jaume et al., 2024).

3.3 Objectives

Reconstruction (RQ1, RQ3): a fixed imputer predicts the unprofiled regions, scored by the per-gene Pearson correlation over those regions averaged over the 50 most variable genes (PCC), the HEST benchmark target (Jaume et al., 2024). *Detection* (RQ2–RQ4): regions of interest (ROIs) are the 20% of regions with the highest local molecular heterogeneity, which we define as the variance of top-50-gene expression across

[1] https://hest.readthedocs.io/en/latest/generated/hest.readers.VisiumHDReader.html
[2] https://huggingface.co/MahmoodLab/UNI2-h

each region's 8 nearest spatial neighbours. The definition is ours; it is motivated by the goal of capturing molecular heterogeneity that drives S2-omics (Yuan et al., 2025), which itself selects regions from histology. The ROI fraction equals the largest budget, so a perfect policy could capture every ROI. We score recall, the fraction of ROIs profiled; an oracle that profiles regions in order of true heterogeneity bounds it from above. Gene sets and ROIs are computed from ground truth and used only for scoring.

3.4 Imputer

One imputer serves every policy, so differences between policies reflect selection alone. It maps image principal components through random Fourier features (Rahimi & Recht, 2007), fits a ridge regression to the profiled regions, and propagates the resulting predictions over a fixed 8-nearest-neighbour graph in image and spatial features while holding profiled regions at their measured values, as in harmonic label propagation (Zhu et al., 2003). Its use of spatial neighbourhoods is inspired by predictors such as STFlow (Huang et al., 2025), but it is far simpler, which makes it cheap enough to refit after every measurement. Its predictions depend on the measured values. Its uncertainty, one minus the graph influence that reaches a region from profiled nodes, depends only on which regions are profiled. A k-nearest-neighbour imputer and a regression-kriging imputer (Hengl et al., 2007) were evaluated on an earlier slide set (Appendix C). Hyperparameters of the imputer and policies were fixed before the registered analysis in which each was first used and were not tuned on its outcomes, except in the registered stage-4 tuning of local-variance (Section 3.10); those of the imputer were set during development on one prostate slide (Appendix B).

3.5 Policies

A *fixed design* is one whose selections do not depend on measured expression; a *feedback policy* is one whose selections do.

Non-adaptive designs, fixed designs computed from images and coordinates alone. Random; farthest-point selection in space (grid), a greedy k-centre cover (Gonzalez, 1985); k-means (Lloyd, 1982) on image embeddings, taking the region nearest each centroid; a one-shot ranker after SpatialFinder (Xu et al., 2026), which scores regions once from image embeddings by rare-cluster membership and distance to the cluster centroid, a simplification of its diversity score without the cell classifier or pathologist labelling ("one-shot" below); and variance- and mutual-information (MI)-greedy placement (Krause et al., 2008) with an RBF kernel on image and coordinate features and a median-heuristic lengthscale (Garreau et al., 2017). Grid, k-means, and MI-greedy are the *coverage designs* of the stage-1 analyses.

Sequential fixed designs. Error-reduction (Roy & McCallum, 2001) picks the region whose 15 nearest unprofiled neighbours in the imputer's feature space carry the most uncertainty, and maximum-uncertainty picks the most uncertain region (Lewis & Gale, 1994). Because the imputer's uncertainty does not depend on measured values, both are fixed designs computed one region at a time; for error-reduction we confirmed that permuted values leave its selections unchanged.

Feedback policies. The *residual* policy keeps the error-reduction form but replaces the uncertainty with an estimate of the imputer's actual error. It computes the leave-one-out residual of the image ridge model at each profiled region from the hat matrix (Hastie et al., 2009), averages it over each unprofiled region's 10 nearest profiled neighbours, and multiplies by one minus the graph influence. The *local-variance* policy, our detection policy, scores a candidate by the kernel-weighted variance of measured expression around it plus 0.5 times its distance to the nearest profiled region, an exploitation term for heterogeneity balanced by an exploration term as in active search (Garnett et al., 2012). While no region has been measured, it selects the region nearest the slide centroid.

Competitor objectives. A diversity sampler applies farthest-point selection in joint image and spatial features, the coverage criterion of core-set active learning (Sener & Savarese, 2018). It approximates the coverage and diversity terms of the SCR^2-ST reward, which rewards covering single-cell states, cell-type diversity, and spatial spread (Zhu et al., 2026a). Although it is a fixed design, it was registered as a competitor, not as a candidate for the feasible design below. An adaptive ROI-seeking sampler follows the reward of SOFisher (Li et al., 2026). Both reimplement stated objectives, not the authors' trained models.

Hybrids (RQ3). A hybrid takes its first $\lceil fn \rceil$ regions, for a budget of n regions and $f \in \{0.5, 0.8\}$ (the 50% and 80% hybrids), from a non-adaptive *base design* and the rest from a feedback policy: the residual policy for reconstruction and local-variance for detection. The base design is the same for every slide at each budget and objective: k-means at 0.5–1% and MI-greedy at 2–20% for reconstruction, and variance-greedy at 2–10% and the one-shot ranker at 20% for detection, chosen from stage-2 results as described under Comparators. This mirrors the space-filling start of adaptive global optimisation (Jones et al., 1998). Because the base designs select in a predetermined order, the first phase is exactly the prefix of the design's own selection (verified for all four designs at both fractions), so a hybrid and its base design differ only in how the last $1 - f$ of the budget is spent.

3.6 Feedback ablations

Each feedback policy and hybrid was also run with uninformative feedback while its selection rule was left unchanged. Under *permuted* feedback, profiling a region reveals the expression of a randomly chosen other region, so the residual policy's leave-one-out model, for example, is fitted to permuted values. Under *constant* feedback, every region appears to have the slide's mean expression. The imputer and the scores always use the true values. A policy that gains from feedback should outperform its own permuted version, the logic of permutation tests for whether a learner exploits real structure (Ojala & Garriga, 2010). Stage 2 used one permutation; stage 3 used two per configuration and repeated the stage-2 ablations with up to four further seeds. Constant feedback cannot mislead, but its effect depends on the rule. Local-variance keeps its exploration term and becomes a coverage rule, so its constant version isolates what the values add. For the residual policy every leave-one-out residual becomes zero, all candidates tie, and the policy selects regions in index order, so its constant version is an arbitrary placement rather than a control (checked post hoc).

3.7 Comparators

The primary stage-2 comparator is a *feasible* design chosen without the target slide. For each held-out study, the non-adaptive design (grid, k-means, variance-greedy, MI-greedy, or one-shot) with the best mean score on the other 17 studies at that budget and objective is applied to the held-out slides, a leave-one-study-out form of cross-study validation (Bernau et al., 2014). The *hindsight benchmark*, the best non-adaptive design for each slide chosen after seeing that slide's result, is reported only for reference, since selecting on the evaluation data inflates the comparator (Varma & Simon, 2006; Cawley & Talbot, 2010). Stage 3 compared each hybrid with its base design, the design chosen as feasible for most held-out studies at that budget and objective. The base designs were chosen on stage-2 results from the same slides, which favours the baseline.

3.8 Statistical analysis and registration

Each margin is a per-slide difference between two policies. We report its mean with a 95% percentile bootstrap interval (Efron & Tibshirani, 1993) that resamples whole studies (Field & Welsh, 2007) (5,000 resamples), and an exact two-sided sign-flip test over the 2^{18} study-level sign patterns (Winkler et al., 2014). Because resampling as few as 18 clusters can give intervals that are too narrow (Cameron et al., 2008), we also report, post hoc, intervals obtained by inverting the sign-flip test (Appendix N). Intervals are not adjusted for multiplicity; p_H denotes p-values adjusted by Holm's procedure within a registered family (Holm, 1979). To make null results interpretable (Altman & Bland, 1995), we report the minimum detectable effect (Bloom, 1995): the smallest true mean margin detected with 80% power (Cohen, 1988), estimated by simulation that resamples studies around the observed dispersion (Arnold et al., 2011). For a family of m margins we compute it at $\alpha = 0.05/m$ (MDE_H), a conservative bound for the Holm decision.

The sign-flip test assumes exchangeable study margins. This holds for a comparator that is the same for every study but not exactly for the feasible one, whose selection for each study uses the other 17. Following the principle that model selection must be repeated inside resampling (Varma & Simon, 2006), we checked the stage-2 results post hoc with a bootstrap that repeats the selection in every replicate and with MI-greedy as the comparator on every slide (Appendix F).

Analyses were registered in the project's version-controlled repository in four stages (Nosek et al., 2018), each before its experiments and after the previous stage's results were known.[3] Stage 1 compared policies with hindsight benchmarks in a family of 24 margins, including the first batched experiments and contiguous blocks of 7 regions around a chosen seed, which approximate field-of-view acquisition (Appendix D). Stage 2 introduced the feasible design, the residual policy, and the feedback ablations, with a primary family of 18 margins: residual minus feasible at six budgets (RQ1), and at four budgets local-variance minus its permuted version, minus the feasible design, and minus the diversity sampler (RQ2). Stage 3 tested the hybrids, with a primary family of 20 margins, each hybrid minus its base design run for the whole budget (RQ3), and a secondary family of 24 that compared hybrids with their permuted versions and repeated the batched experiments with the base detection design and permuted controls (RQ4). Stage 4 (Section 3.10) had primary families of 12 margins on a common evaluation set (residual and 50% reconstruction hybrid against their comparators at six budgets), 9 at tile scale, and 4 for tuning, and a secondary family of 30 with the MSE, detection-hybrid, and constant-feedback contrasts. In every stage a benefit was to be claimed only for a positive margin with $p_H < 0.05$. Results are labelled confirmatory (registered primary), secondary (registered, Holm within the secondary family), descriptive, or post hoc.

3.9 Positive controls

A null result is informative only if the protocol could have registered an effect. In synthetic slides of 20×20 regions with spatially clustered structure that the image cannot predict (8 slides per setting, 10% budget, k-NN imputer), we varied the correlation length of the hidden structure and the amplitude a_{ROI} with which ROIs appear in measured expression. Synthetic margins are taken over the hindsight benchmark of the simple designs: the better of grid and k-means on each slide, and for detection also random. On the 22 real slides we injected 20 genes carrying three spatial hotspots of radius 5% of the slide diagonal, in the manner of simulated spatially variable genes (Svensson et al., 2018), with standard deviation equal to a spike amplitude $a_{\mathrm{spike}} \in \{0, 1, 2\}$ times the median of the slide's top-50 genes. Because the image cannot predict the hotspots, only measured values reveal them. Before running this control we set its success criterion: the residual policy beats the feasible design with an interval excluding zero at $a_{\mathrm{spike}} = 2$.

3.10 Stage-4 protocol

Stage 4 addressed four limits of the earlier stages. *Common evaluation set*: a fixed random 20% of each slide's regions was withheld from selection, and every policy was scored on it by PCC and mean squared error (MSE) over the top-50 genes; budgets count all regions. *Tiles*: spots were pooled into 300 μm squares with at least three spots (mean expression and embedding), budgets were 12, 24, and 48 tiles, the ROIs were the 20% of tiles with the highest within-tile variance of the top-50 genes, and policies ran one tile at a time or in 2 or 4 rounds, with 20% of tiles withheld for reconstruction. *Tuning*: under the stage-2 protocol, local-variance was run with exploration weight $\{0.25, 0.5, 1, 2\}$ and kernel width $\{0.05, 0.1, 0.2\}$ of the slide diagonal, and for each held-out study the setting with the best mean recall on the other studies was applied, as for the feasible design. *Headroom*: on one slide per tissue at 0.5–2%, a greedy selection added, among 48 random candidates, the region that most increased held-out PCC computed with the true expression. It selects on its own evaluation score, so it is an optimistic bound, not a policy.

4 Results

4.1 Positive controls

The simulator registered an effect of feedback on detection. In synthetic slides, the local-variance policy's recall margin over this benchmark rose with ROI amplitude, from -0.045 at $a_{\mathrm{ROI}} = 0$ to $+0.052$ (95% CI $+0.033$ to $+0.071$) at $a_{\mathrm{ROI}} = 4$ and $+0.101$ ($+0.065$ to $+0.135$) at $a_{\mathrm{ROI}} = 8$, positive on all 8 slides at both amplitudes (Figure 1b). Reconstruction behaved differently: even an oracle that orders regions by true local

[3] Verbatim excerpts of the four plans and their commit dates are in the supplementary material (`registered_plans/`); the plans label RQ4 as Q3.

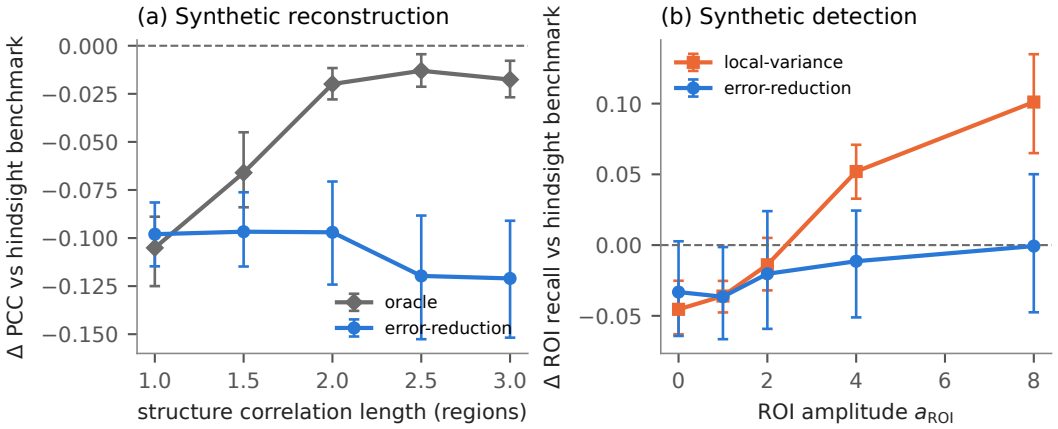


Figure 1: Synthetic controls (8 slides per point, 10% budget, mean and 95% bootstrap CI over slides). (a) Reconstruction margin over the hindsight benchmark of grid and k-means versus the correlation length of the hidden structure, for the oracle ordering by true local difficulty and for error-reduction. (b) Detection-recall margin over the benchmark of random, grid, and k-means versus ROI amplitude.

difficulty, which no policy could deploy, stayed below the benchmark at every correlation length, by 0.105 and 0.066 PCC at the two shortest and 0.013 to 0.020 at the longer ones (Figure 1a).

The semi-synthetic control failed its criterion. At $a_{\mathrm{spike}} = 1$ and 2, all 20 injected genes entered the evaluation set on every slide, yet at $a_{\mathrm{spike}} = 2$ the residual policy remained below the feasible design, by 0.021 (0.012 to 0.030) PCC at 5% and 0.011 (0.004 to 0.019) at 10%, close to its deficits without injection (0.015 and 0.007; Figure 2c, Appendix H). Feedback still helped relative to permuted values, by +0.001 to +0.013. The protocol can thus register a large detection effect, but not demonstrably a reconstruction gain, and the RQ1 results below concern the tested policies.

4.2 RQ1: Reconstruction

No feedback policy outperformed the feasible design (Table 1, Appendix Table 13, Figure 2a). The residual policy fell below it at every budget, by 0.092 PCC at 0.5%, 0.057 at 1%, 0.025 at 2%, 0.016 at 5%, 0.007 at 10%, and 0.002 at 20%, significantly so at 0.5, 1, 5, and 10% ($p_H \leq 0.010$). The local-variance policy was further below, by 0.119 to 0.163 (secondary, $p_H \leq 0.001$). Bootstrap intervals that repeat the comparator's selection in each replicate excluded zero at every budget (post hoc; Appendix F).

The measured values nonetheless carried information. With informative rather than permuted feedback, the residual policy gained 0.031, 0.039, and 0.030 PCC at 0.5–2% (secondary, Appendix G; p_H 0.056, 0.002, 0.014), with no difference at 10–20%. Feedback moved the policy toward the feasible design without closing the gap. The error-reduction design, which shares the residual policy's structure but uses value-independent uncertainty, trailed the feasible design by similar amounts (0.107, 0.067, and 0.024 at 0.5–2%; post hoc), and both converged on it as the budget grew. The only design to exceed the feasible design was maximum-uncertainty, by 0.003 PCC at 20% (95% CI 0.002 to 0.004, $p = 0.0007$, post hoc), a fixed design that uses no feedback. The hindsight benchmark exceeded the feasible design by 0.016 to 0.021 PCC at budgets up to 2% and by at most 0.002 above (Appendix E).

4.3 RQ2: Detection

Informative feedback raised the local-variance policy's recall over permuted feedback by 0.005, 0.017, 0.029, and 0.063 at 2, 5, 10, and 20% (Figure 2b, Appendix Table 12). The unadjusted bootstrap intervals excluded zero at 5–20%, but intervals from inverting the sign-flip test did so only at 20% (Appendix N); no margin survived adjustment ($p_H \geq 0.29$), and each estimate lay below its MDE_H (0.015, 0.035, 0.066, 0.112). The

Table 1: Reconstruction accuracy (PCC over the top-50 genes on unprofiled regions), mean over 22 slides. "Feasible" is the non-adaptive design chosen on the other studies; "hindsight" is the hindsight benchmark. "Residual, perm." is the residual policy given permuted feedback.

	Non-adaptive		Sequential fixed design		Feedback		
Budget	feasible	hindsight	error-red.	max-unc.	residual	residual, perm.	local-var.
0.5%	0.449	0.470	0.343	0.348	0.357	0.327	0.348
1%	0.534	0.550	0.467	0.462	0.477	0.438	0.424
2%	0.591	0.607	0.567	0.562	0.566	0.536	0.471
5%	0.659	0.660	0.650	0.648	0.643	0.633	0.513
10%	0.685	0.687	0.684	0.685	0.678	0.677	0.535
20%	0.707	0.709	0.708	0.710	0.705	0.705	0.544

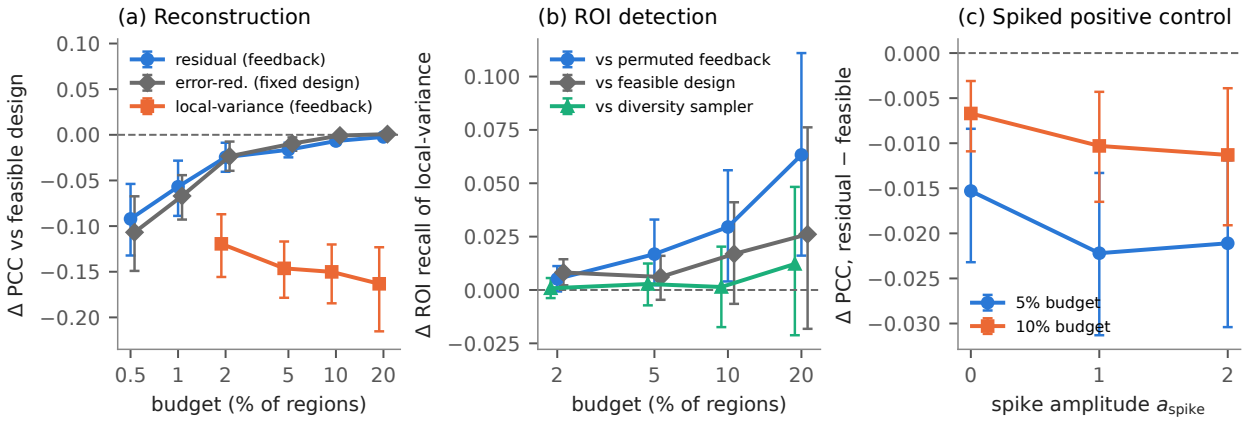


Figure 2: Stage-2 margins over 22 slides, mean and unadjusted 95% CI resampling studies. (a) Reconstruction margin over the feasible design. (b) Detection-recall margin of the local-variance policy over its permuted-feedback version, the feasible design, and the diversity sampler. (c) Spiked control: residual policy minus feasible design by spike amplitude.

margin over the feasible design was smaller (0.006 to 0.026, $p_H \geq 0.25$), and the margin over the diversity sampler was close to zero (0.001 to 0.012, $p_H = 1.000$).

All designs stayed close to random selection, which captures on average the budget fraction of the ROIs (Table 2). At 20% the local-variance policy exceeded this expectation by 0.078 recall (95% CI from sign-flip inversion 0.029 to 0.125) and the feasible design by 0.052, while at 2% the feasible design was slightly below it (0.018 against 0.020). The oracle reached 0.999 at 20%, so every policy captured only a small part of the heterogeneity available to it (post hoc; Appendix N).

The absolute recalls locate the feedback effect (Table 2). At 20%, the policy recovered 0.278 of the ROIs with informative feedback but only 0.215 with permuted and 0.204 with constant values, below the feasible design (0.252); the diversity sampler reached 0.266 without feedback. Part of the feedback effect therefore recovers ground that the selection rule loses on its own. The margin over constant feedback at 20% was the only significant detection effect of feedback in stage 2 (+0.074, $p_H = 0.038$, secondary).

The apparent advantage also depends on the comparator. Against MI-greedy used on every slide, the local-variance policy gained 0.043 and 0.078 recall at 10 and 20% ($p_H = 0.043$ for both; post hoc). MI-greedy, however, is a reconstruction design whose detection recall never exceeded that expected of random selection (0.200 at 20%, against 0.247 for variance-greedy and 0.252 for the one-shot ranker), so this comparison shows only that feedback beats chance-level placement. Selection-aware intervals against the feasible design included zero at every budget (Appendix F). The ROI-seeking port did not improve on the coverage designs

Table 2: ROI-detection recall, mean over 22 slides. "Random" is the recall expected of random selection (n/N for n of N regions). "Informative", "permuted", and "constant" denote the local-variance policy with informative, permuted, and constant feedback. The oracle profiles regions in order of true heterogeneity.

		Non-adaptive				Feedback (local variance)			
Budget	random	feasible	k-means	MI-greedy	diversity	informative	permuted	constant	oracle
2%	0.020	0.018	0.018	0.018	0.026	0.027	0.021	0.022	0.100
5%	0.050	0.064	0.050	0.046	0.067	0.070	0.053	0.051	0.250
10%	0.100	0.120	0.110	0.094	0.136	0.137	0.107	0.103	0.500
20%	0.200	0.252	0.232	0.200	0.266	0.278	0.215	0.204	0.999

in stage 1 (Appendix D); it is not a test of the trained SOFisher, which learned on its own data in a native run (Appendix M). SCR^2-ST's processed training data were not public.

4.4 RQ3: Feedback on top of a fixed design

No hybrid outperformed its base design (Table 3, Appendix Figure 3). For reconstruction, the hybrids recovered most of the residual policy's deficit, but the 50% hybrid remained below k-means at 0.5%, by 0.036 PCC ($p_H = 0.006$), and from 2% upward every hybrid was within 0.007 PCC of MI-greedy with no significant margin. For detection, every hybrid margin lay between -0.003 and $+0.006$ recall ($p_H \geq 0.76$). These nulls are tight: at 2–10% the MDE_H values were 0.004 to 0.017 PCC and 0.004 to 0.026 recall, so gains above about 0.02 PCC or 0.03 recall would probably have been detected. At 20% the detection bound widens to 0.035–0.068.

The hybrids responded to the values they were shown. With permuted values they did worse at 2%, by 0.016 and 0.007 PCC for the two reconstruction hybrids and 0.007 recall for the 50% detection hybrid (secondary, $p_H \leq 0.027$). For that detection hybrid the difference grew to 0.014–0.035 at 5–20% without surviving correction; for reconstruction at 10–20% the permuted versions were marginally ahead, by at most 0.003 PCC ($p_H \geq 0.12$; Appendix I). In absolute terms (Table 17), with permuted values the feedback phase lost ground relative to continuing the base design, for example from 0.127 to 0.110 recall at 10%, and informative values brought the hybrid back to about the level of the design (0.133). Because permuted values can actively mislead, this shows that informative values did better than wrong ones, not that they added to the design. In detection, the local-variance policy run alone (0.137 at 10%, 0.278 at 20%) scored above both hybrids at every budget (descriptive).

4.5 RQ4: Batched and contiguous acquisition (exploratory)

In stage 1, at 10% budget, the local-variance policy's detection margins over the hindsight benchmark of the coverage designs were +0.021, +0.034, and +0.011 for rounds of 1, 5, and 25 regions and +0.024 for contiguous blocks, none with $p_H < 0.05$ (Appendix D). With a single round the policy has no measurements and selects the regions nearest the slide centroid, its rule while no region is measured; the resulting margin of -0.051 ($p_H = 0.008$) reflects that rule rather than adaptivity. Reconstruction margins were negative in every setting.

In stage 3, rounds of 5 regions did not reduce recall: the policy captured 0.150 and 0.288 of ROIs at 10 and 20%, slightly more than when choosing one region at a time (0.137 and 0.278; Appendix Table 16). Its margins over the base detection design (+0.023, +0.035) and over permuted feedback (+0.050, +0.084) did not survive correction ($p_H \geq 0.11$).

4.6 Stage 4: common evaluation set, tuning, tiles, and headroom

Common evaluation set. Scoring every policy on the same withheld regions left the reconstruction conclusions unchanged (Table 4). The residual policy stayed below the feasible design at 0.5, 1, and 2%, by 0.082, 0.062, and 0.032 PCC ($p_H \leq 0.012$), no margin above zero was established at any budget, and MSE agreed

Table 3: Stage-3 primary margins: hybrid minus its base design run for the whole budget, 22 slides. The 50% and 80% hybrids take that share of regions from the base design and the rest from the feedback policy. Δ with unadjusted 95% CI resampling studies; p_H Holm-adjusted over the 20 primary margins; MDE_H at 80% power and $\alpha = 0.05/20$.

		50% hybrid			80% hybrid		
Budget	base design	Δ [95% CI]	p_H	MDE_H	Δ [95% CI]	p_H	MDE_H
Reconstruction (PCC); feedback: residual policy							
0.5%	k-means	-0.036 $[-0.057, -0.018]$	0.006	0.056	-0.009 $[-0.021, +0.003]$	1.000	0.033
1%	k-means	-0.010 $[-0.020, +0.002]$	1.000	0.021	-0.009 $[-0.019, -0.001]$	1.000	0.025
2%	MI-greedy	$+0.001$ $[-0.007, +0.011]$	1.000	0.017	$+0.007$ $[+0.002, +0.013]$	0.359	0.013
5%	MI-greedy	-0.003 $[-0.007, +0.002]$	1.000	0.013	-0.001 $[-0.004, +0.003]$	1.000	0.008
10%	MI-greedy	0.000 $[-0.002, +0.002]$	1.000	0.005	$+0.001$ $[-0.001, +0.002]$	1.000	0.004
20%	MI-greedy	-0.002 $[-0.004, +0.000]$	1.000	0.005	-0.001 $[-0.003, +0.001]$	1.000	0.006
Detection (ROI recall); feedback: local-variance policy							
2%	variance-greedy	$+0.003$ $[+0.000, +0.005]$	0.756	0.007	0.000 $[-0.001, +0.002]$	1.000	0.004
5%	variance-greedy	$+0.002$ $[-0.007, +0.010]$	1.000	0.020	0.000 $[-0.003, +0.003]$	1.000	0.008
10%	variance-greedy	$+0.006$ $[-0.005, +0.018]$	1.000	0.026	$+0.001$ $[-0.005, +0.007]$	1.000	0.015
20%	one-shot	0.000 $[-0.033, +0.034]$	1.000	0.068	-0.003 $[-0.019, +0.014]$	1.000	0.035

(Appendix J). The 50% hybrid was within 0.019 PCC of its base design at every budget, with no significant margin. The local-variance policy's PCC deficit on the common set was 0.118 at 2% against 0.120 in stage 2, and 0.093 against 0.163 at 20% (descriptive); the common set changes both the scored regions and the candidate pool, so we do not attribute the difference to either.

Value of the measurements. Against its constant-feedback version, a coverage rule, the local-variance policy gained 0.010 to 0.096 recall, significantly at 20% ($p_H = 0.012$), and the 50% detection hybrid gained 0.020 and 0.036 at 5 and 10% ($p_H \leq 0.022$; secondary). For detection, the values therefore added information beyond coverage. For reconstruction the evidence is weaker than in stage 2. The residual policy's constant-feedback margins are listed in Appendix J but not interpreted, because that version selects in index order (Section 3.6), and its margin over permuted feedback fell to 0.017, 0.011, and 0.011 PCC at 0.5–2%, none significant, against 0.031 to 0.039 in stage 2 (descriptive).

Tuning. Tuning changed the registered detection conclusion. With its settings chosen for each held-out study on the other studies, the local-variance policy beat the feasible detection design by 0.016, 0.023, and 0.049 recall at 2, 5, and 10% ($p_H = 0.001$, 0.013, 0.013), and by 0.064 at 20% ($p_H = 0.072$; Table 4). Every study received the grid's narrowest kernel, 0.05 of the slide diagonal against the registered 0.1 (descriptive). Post hoc checks support and qualify the gain (Appendix Table 23). It held under a bootstrap that repeats both choices in every replicate (2–10%) and against constant feedback (+0.012 to +0.112, $p_H \leq 0.003$; an approximate control, Appendix J). But with Holm over all 25 stage-4 primary margins only the 2% margin stays below 0.05, and the diversity sampler, which would have been the feasible design for every study had it been a candidate, came within 0.009 to 0.050 recall ($p_H = 0.10$).

Tiles. With 300 μm tiles, no feedback policy beat the feasible design for reconstruction or detection, and local-variance in two rounds fell below it at 48 tiles (-0.059 recall, $p_H = 0.015$; Appendix J). Local-variance and the feasible design again captured heterogeneous tiles close to the random rate (within 0.047 recall of it). These nulls are loose: MDE_H ranged from 0.038 to 0.117 PCC and from 0.036 to 0.083 recall.

Headroom. On four slides at 0.5–2%, the greedy bound exceeded the best fixed design by 0.026 to 0.166 PCC, while the residual policy stayed below the fixed design in all 12 cases (Appendix J). Because the bound selects on the score it is evaluated on, much of this gap may be optimism, and it does not show that a deployable policy could do better (descriptive).

Table 4: Stage-4 primary margins, 22 slides. Reconstruction margins are scored on regions withheld from every policy; the tuned policy's settings are chosen for each held-out study on the other studies. Δ with unadjusted 95% CI resampling studies; p_H Holm-adjusted within the registered family (12 common-set margins; 4 tuning margins).

	residual − feasible (PCC)		50% hybrid − base design (PCC)			tuned local-variance − feasible (recall)	
Budget	Δ [95% CI]	p_H	base design	Δ [95% CI]	p_H	Δ [95% CI]	p_H
0.5%	−0.082 [−0.123, −0.040]	0.012	k-means	−0.019 [−0.040, +0.001]	0.430	–	–
1%	−0.062 [−0.077, −0.048]	<0.001	k-means	−0.014 [−0.027, −0.001]	0.407	–	–
2%	−0.032 [−0.043, −0.019]	0.009	MI-greedy	+0.002 [−0.009, +0.016]	1.000	+0.016 [+0.009, +0.023]	<0.001
5%	−0.011 [−0.018, −0.003]	0.157	MI-greedy	+0.004 [−0.001, +0.009]	0.430	+0.023 [+0.009, +0.038]	0.013
10%	−0.002 [−0.007, +0.005]	1.000	MI-greedy	+0.003 [0.000, +0.006]	0.407	+0.049 [+0.016, +0.088]	0.013
20%	+0.003 [0.000, +0.006]	0.430	MI-greedy	+0.003 [0.000, +0.005]	0.407	+0.064 [+0.004, +0.134]	0.072

4.7 Robustness

Further permutation seeds (seed-to-seed standard deviations at most 0.007 PCC and 0.013 recall; Appendix I) and evaluation genes chosen on a 15% reference subset or taken from all filtered genes (Appendix K) changed no conclusion. Stage-1 detection margins were larger on Visium HD than on Visium (+0.048 against +0.008 at 10%; exploratory), but platform is confounded with study (Appendix L).

5 Discussion

Reconstruction. Informative feedback beat permuted feedback by up to 0.039 PCC in stage 2 but by at most 0.017, not significantly, on the common set, and neither the policy nor the hybrids improved on a fixed design. Permuted values can mislead a policy, and constant values reduce the residual policy to index order, so neither contrast measures how much the values were worth for reconstruction. The pattern fits sensor-placement theory, under which placement matters more than the observed values when uncertainty depends on locations alone (Krause et al., 2008). Our imputer's uncertainty has this property while its predictions do not, so any benefit of feedback had to come through the predictions. The evaluation does not test the theory, and because neither positive control showed that a reconstruction gain could be detected and the residual policy was not tuned, it cannot rule out a better feedback policy. What it establishes is that the residual policy, which targets the imputer's own error and received exact measurements, lost to a fixed design chosen without the target slide.

Detection. Feedback beat weak baselines, and once tuned it beat the registered detection designs. It outperformed MI-greedy, a reconstruction design that performed at chance level for detection (post hoc), and its own constant-feedback version, a coverage rule, at the largest budget; such gains are what active-search reasoning predicts (Garnett et al., 2012), and the synthetic control confirmed that the simulator detects them. With its registered settings, the policy's margins over a design chosen for detection and over a diversity sampler were small and not significant, and the diversity sampler's near-parity indicates that heterogeneous regions on these slides are spread widely enough for broad coverage to find many of them. With a narrower kernel chosen on other studies, the policy beat the detection design by 0.016 to 0.049 recall at 2–10% and its own constant-feedback version by more, so the measured values contributed. The gain is modest: the diversity sampler came within 0.009 to 0.033 recall of the tuned policy at 2–10%, every design stayed close to random selection, and the oracle shows how much heterogeneity all of them missed.

Implications. For developers of adaptive acquisition, the lessons are methodological. Beating random selection is not evidence that feedback helps, and three comparisons should be standard: the strongest fixed designs available, simple diversity samplers included, chosen on other data for the same objective, the method itself fed uninformative values that leave its selection rule working, and the method with settings chosen on held-out data, since our registered settings understated what local-variance could do. Inference should treat studies, not slides, as the unit. For experimentalists, within simulated acquisition at 0.5–20% of regions or 12–48 tiles, one imputer, and computationally defined endpoints, a fixed design is the practical default

for reconstruction: k-means at the smallest budgets and MI-greedy above them. It is computed before any measurement, avoids the turnaround that sequential selection requires, and won under conditions generous to feedback, since simulated measurements are exact and arrive at once. For capturing heterogeneous spots, a tuned feedback policy offers 0.02 to 0.05 recall at 2–10% over the registered detection designs and 0.01 to 0.03 over a diversity sampler, which has to be weighed against that turnaround; at tile scale it offered no detectable gain. Whether these results hold for other predictors or annotated biological targets would need prospective or annotated data. They agree with the benchmark's result for predictor training (Zhu et al., 2026b), although the two studies address different decisions.

Limitations. *Simulation.* The simulator is retrospective: a revealed region returns its measured expression without added noise, batch effects, or delay, conditions that if anything favour feedback. Spots and 128 μm HD pseudo-spots are not units any platform selects individually; the 300 μm tiles are closer to an ROI but are still simulated. The batch and block simulations approximate but do not validate any platform.

Endpoints. The ROIs are the 20% of regions with the highest local-variance score, not annotated structures; high local variance can mark tissue boundaries, mixtures of cell types, or technical noise as well as targets such as tumour margins or immune niches. The detection results therefore concern computational heterogeneity and do not show whether feedback helps find a particular biological target. The local-variance policy estimates from measured values the same kind of statistic that defines the ROIs, and tuning moved its kernel toward the ROIs' neighbourhood scale, so the detection comparisons are set up favourably for feedback.

Models and policies. The 22-slide results use one imputer, whose hyperparameters were set on one of the 22 slides (excluding it changed no conclusion; Appendix N); the k-NN and kriging comparisons rest on five slides. The two feedback policies are hand-built heuristics. Tuning local-variance changed the detection result, and the residual policy was not tuned, so the reconstruction result bounds what this policy achieves, not what feedback can achieve. At the tuned kernel width a numerical floor in the policy perturbs its first picks (Appendix J). The competitor samplers reimplement objectives; SOFisher was run natively only on its own data and SCR^2-ST not at all.

Inference. The registered stage-2 ablation tests use one permutation, with further seeds descriptive. Multiplicity is controlled within each registered family, not across the four stages or the post hoc analyses. The plans were registered in our own version-controlled repository rather than with an external registry, so their timing rests on commit records, which the supplementary material lists; each stage's design was chosen after earlier results were known, although each was registered before its experiments. The stage-4 constant-feedback contrasts for the residual policy, though registered, are not a valid control. The diversity sampler was a competitor, not a feasible-design candidate, which favours feedback in the detection comparisons. Budgets above 20% were not tested.

6 Conclusion

Across 22 human slides from 18 studies and four registered stages, the feedback policies we tested did not earn their measurement turnaround for reconstruction: the residual policy was significantly worse than a well-chosen fixed design at small budgets, also when every policy was scored on the same withheld regions, and spending only the remainder of the budget on feedback did not improve on that design. For capturing heterogeneous regions, the registered policy did not detectably beat a design built for detection, but with settings chosen on other studies it did, by 0.02 to 0.05 recall at 2–10%, though not detectably better than a diversity sampler without feedback. The strongest objective-matched fixed baselines, uninformative-feedback controls, tuning on held-out data, and study-level inference with positive controls and minimum detectable effects separate the value of feedback from the value of a good selection rule; new adaptive acquisition methods should be judged against them.

Reproducibility. The supplementary material contains the code, configuration, result files, the registered plans with their commit dates, and scripts that regenerate every table and figure. A public repository will be linked on acceptance; HEST-1k and UNI2-h are available from their providers.

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A Slides

Table 5 lists the slides. "Cluster" indexes the HEST study used as the resampling unit, and "Pitch" is the median nearest-neighbour spacing of regions.

Table 5: The 22 slides (HEST-1k v1.3 metadata).

Tissue	HEST ID	Platform	Spots	μm/px	Pitch (μm)	Cluster	Study (HEST dataset title)
prostate	TENX174	Visium HD	2385	0.274	128	1	Visium HD Spatial Gene Expression Library, Human Prostate ...
prostate	TENX40	Visium	4371	0.345	100	2	Human Prostate Cancer, Adenocarcinoma with Invasive Carcin...
prostate	MEND160	Visium	4079	0.573	100	3	Spatially resolved clonal copy number alterations in benig...
prostate	TENX46	Visium	3043	0.344	100	4	Human Prostate Cancer, Acinar Cell Carcinoma (FFPE)
prostate	TENX41	Visium	2543	0.345	100	5	Normal Human Prostate (FFPE)
prostate	MEND144	Visium	4074	0.341	100	3	Spatially resolved clonal copy number alterations in benig...
kidney	TENX173	Visium HD	2684	0.274	128	6	Visium HD Spatial Gene Expression Library, Human Kidney (F...
kidney	TENX71	Visium	5936	0.274	100	7	Human Kidney, 11 mm Capture Area (FFPE)
kidney	INT21	Visium	4975	0.457	100	8	Tertiary lymphoid structures generate and propagate anti-t...
kidney	INT19	Visium	4948	0.457	100	8	Tertiary lymphoid structures generate and propagate anti-t...
lung	TENX171	Visium HD	1766	0.274	128	9	Visium HD Spatial Gene Expression Libraries, Post-Xenium, ...
lung	TENX170	Visium HD	1877	0.274	128	9	Visium HD Spatial Gene Expression Libraries, Post-Xenium, ...
lung	TENX163	Visium HD	2487	0.274	128	10	Visium HD Spatial Gene Expression Library, Human Lung Canc...
lung	TENX72	Visium	6195	0.274	100	11	Human Lung Cancer, 11 mm Capture Area (FFPE)
lung	TENX62	Visium	3858	0.273	100	12	Human Lung Cancer (FFPE)
lung	MISC20	Visium	3316	0.438	100	13	A spatially resolved atlas of the human lung characterizes...
colon	TENX156	Visium HD	2179	0.274	128	14	Characterization of immune cell populations in the tumor m...
colon	TENX155	Visium HD	2281	0.274	128	14	Characterization of immune cell populations in the tumor m...
colon	TENX70	Visium	9080	0.274	100	15	Human Colorectal Cancer, 11 mm Capture Area (FFPE)
colon	TENX92	Visium	6518	0.274	100	16	Visium CytAssist Gene Expression Libraries of Post-Xenium ...
colon	MISC47	Visium	4818	0.276	100	17	COLON MAP: Colon Molecular Atlas Project
colon	ZEN48	Visium	2385	0.459	100	18	Charting the Heterogeneity of Colorectal Cancer Consensus ...

Changes from an earlier seven-slide analysis. An earlier analysis used seven Visium HD slides and described regions as 112 μm squares. The current HEST metadata lists two of those slides as non-human (TENX186, *Mus musculus*; TENX175, mixed human and mouse), and both are excluded here. The loader had also assumed 0.5 μm/px, whereas the HD images are about 0.274 μm/px, so those regions were about 61 μm squares containing one pseudo-spot each. On the five retained slides, per-slide local-variance margins (reconstruction and detection, four budgets) differ between the two analyses by a median of 0.015 (maximum 0.096); 3 of 40 change sign, two by less than 0.005 and one detection margin from -0.050 to $+0.015$. With seven slides the smallest attainable exact p-value is 0.016, so no earlier margin could have survived correction for 24 comparisons.

B Configuration and implementation checks

All values are fixed in the released `config.py`. The imputer's hyperparameters were set during development on one prostate slide (TENX174, one of the 22) before any registered analysis and were not changed afterwards; the policies' hyperparameters were fixed before the stage in which each policy first appears.

Seeds: global 2021; random policy $\{0, \ldots, 4\}$; the stage-2 permutation uses the global seed, and stage 3 uses seeds 1 and 2 (1–4 for the repeated local-variance ablation). Imputer: image PCA 64, random Fourier features 512 (median-heuristic bandwidth), ridge 10, graph $k = 8$, 20 propagation steps, step size 0.5. k-NN imputer: $k = 10$, joint image and space features. Kriging: image PCA 64, ridge 10, residual $k = 10$. Placement kernels: feature PCA 64, median-heuristic lengthscale, noise 10^{-2}. Error-reduction and residual policies: neighbourhood 15; the residual policy uses the 256 genes with the highest variance among profiled regions and 10 profiled neighbours. Local-variance: spatial kernel width 0.1 of the slide diagonal, exploration weight 0.5. Hybrids: coverage fraction $f \in \{0.5, 0.8\}$, rounded up. Batched stage-3 runs: rounds of 5. Spiked control: 20 genes, 3 hotspots, radius 0.05 of the diagonal, noise 0.1 of the reference standard deviation. Statistics: 5,000 bootstrap resamples; exact sign-flip enumeration over studies; MDE from 300 study resamples with 3,000 sign flips each, on a grid of 51 effect sizes.

The code for the larger slides replaces dense distance computations with sparse and incremental ones; a 132-run check (11 policies, 3 imputers, 2 slide sizes, 2 budgets) reproduced the original code's selections and scores exactly. In the stage-2 run, the five non-adaptive designs reproduced the stage-1 per-slide scores exactly, and the local-variance and diversity policies reproduced their stage-1 means. A caching error interrupted the first stage-2 run. For the results saved before it, a stale cache entry could only have produced a crash, and the error was fixed before any result was analysed.

C Imputer comparison on the earlier slide set

The k-NN and kriging imputers were run only on the earlier slide set. Table 6 reports error-reduction minus the hindsight benchmark on the five human slides from that run, whose regions held one pseudo-spot each, with the number of slides on which the margin was positive. With five slides these values are descriptive.

Table 6: Error-reduction minus the hindsight benchmark (PCC), mean over 5 human Visium HD slides (positive/total).

Budget	kNN	kriging	graphflow
0.5%	−0.088 (0/5)	−0.088 (2/5)	−0.082 (0/5)
1%	−0.114 (0/5)	−0.138 (1/5)	−0.083 (0/5)
2%	−0.091 (0/5)	−0.150 (1/5)	−0.040 (0/5)
5%	−0.121 (0/5)	−0.141 (1/5)	−0.011 (1/5)
10%	−0.134 (0/5)	−0.133 (0/5)	−0.000 (2/5)
20%	−0.145 (0/5)	−0.126 (0/5)	−0.002 (2/5)

D Stage-1 results

Stage 1 compared policies with hindsight benchmarks. Table 7 gives its 24-margin primary family except the batched and contiguous settings, which are in Table 8; Table 9 gives absolute recall, including the ROI-seeking sampler.

Table 7: Stage-1 primary margins against hindsight benchmarks: for error-reduction, the best of the five non-adaptive designs on each slide; for local-variance, the best of the three coverage designs. Unadjusted 95% CIs resampling studies; p_H Holm-adjusted over the 24 stage-1 primary margins.

	Reconstruction (PCC, top-50 genes)				Detection (ROI recall)	
	error-reduction − hindsight (non-adapt.)		local-var. − hindsight (coverage)		local-var. − hindsight (coverage)	
Budget	Δ [95% CI]	p_H	Δ [95% CI]	p_H	Δ [95% CI]	p_H
0.5%	−0.128 [−0.162, −0.096]	<0.001	–	–	–	–
1%	−0.083 [−0.105, −0.064]	<0.001	–	–	–	–
2%	−0.040 [−0.054, −0.027]	<0.001	−0.136 [−0.171, −0.106]	<0.001	+0.001 [−0.004, +0.006]	0.723
5%	−0.011 [−0.018, −0.004]	0.057	−0.148 [−0.180, −0.119]	<0.001	+0.013 [+0.002, +0.024]	0.362
10%	−0.002 [−0.007, +0.001]	0.687	−0.152 [−0.186, −0.122]	<0.001	+0.021 [+0.003, +0.037]	0.362
20%	−0.002 [−0.004, +0.001]	0.687	−0.165 [−0.217, −0.125]	<0.001	+0.042 [+0.006, +0.077]	0.362

Table 8: Stage-1 local-variance policy minus the hindsight benchmark of the coverage designs at 10% budget under batched and contiguous acquisition. Δ with unadjusted 95% CI resampling studies; p_H Holm-adjusted over the 24 stage-1 primary margins.

	Reconstruction (PCC)		Detection (ROI recall)	
Acquisition setting	Δ [95% CI]	p_H	Δ [95% CI]	p_H
Sequential (1 region per round)	-0.152 $[-0.186, -0.122]$	<0.001	$+0.021$ $[+0.003, +0.037]$	0.362
Rounds of 5 regions	-0.129 $[-0.175, -0.094]$	<0.001	$+0.034$ $[+0.013, +0.053]$	0.073
Rounds of 25 regions	-0.130 $[-0.176, -0.095]$	<0.001	$+0.011$ $[-0.000, +0.021]$	0.362
Single round (whole budget)	-0.236 $[-0.288, -0.188]$	<0.001	-0.051 $[-0.077, -0.027]$	0.008
Contiguous blocks of 7 regions	-0.087 $[-0.116, -0.063]$	<0.001	$+0.024$ $[+0.002, +0.044]$	0.362

Table 9: Stage-1 ROI-detection recall, mean over 22 slides. †Reimplementations of the stated objectives of SCR^2-ST (diversity, non-adaptive) and SOFisher (ROI-seeking, adaptive). *Ground-truth ordering.

	Non-adaptive coverage			Competitor objectives			
Budget	k-means	grid	MI-greedy	diversity†	ROI-seeking†	local-var.	oracle*
2%	0.018	0.022	0.018	0.026	0.021	0.027	0.100
5%	0.050	0.051	0.046	0.067	0.050	0.070	0.250
10%	0.110	0.103	0.094	0.136	0.104	0.137	0.500
20%	0.232	0.204	0.200	0.266	0.232	0.278	0.999

E Feasible design choices and the hindsight gap

The leave-one-study-out choice selected k-means for reconstruction at 0.5–1% and MI-greedy at 2–20% (with k-means for 4 of 18 studies at 2%), and for detection variance-greedy for most studies at 2–10% and the one-shot ranker at 20% (Table 10).

Table 10: Designs chosen on the other studies (number of held-out studies, of 18) and the difference between the hindsight benchmark and the feasible design for reconstruction (unadjusted 95% CI resampling studies).

Budget	feasible choice, reconstruction	feasible choice, detection	hindsight benchmark − feasible (PCC)
0.5%	kmeans (18)	–	$+0.021$ $[+0.006, +0.038]$
1%	kmeans (18)	–	$+0.016$ $[+0.006, +0.027]$
2%	mi-greedy (14), kmeans (4)	var-greedy (12), oneshot (5), grid (1)	$+0.017$ $[+0.008, +0.027]$
5%	mi-greedy (18)	var-greedy (18)	$+0.001$ $[+0.000, +0.003]$
10%	mi-greedy (18)	var-greedy (16), oneshot (2)	$+0.001$ $[+0.001, +0.003]$
20%	mi-greedy (18)	oneshot (18)	$+0.002$ $[+0.001, +0.003]$

F Inference for the feasible design

The feasible design for each held-out study is chosen from the other 17, so the 18 study margins share the selection step, which the study-level tests in the main text do not account for. Two post hoc checks address this (Table 11). The selection-aware bootstrap resamples studies with replacement and repeats the leave-one-study-out choice inside each replicate, excluding copies of the held-out study from its own selection, so its interval reflects uncertainty in which design is chosen. The single-design analysis uses MI-greedy on every slide in place of the feasible design, for which the sign-flip test is valid as specified, with Holm over the 18 analogous margins (the feedback and diversity margins do not involve the comparator and are unchanged). For reconstruction both checks agree with the main analysis. For detection the selection-aware intervals include zero at every budget, whereas the MI-greedy margins exclude it at 10–20%; MI-greedy has the lowest detection recall in the pool at 5–20%.

Table 11: Stage-2 primary margins against the feasible design with selection-aware 95% bootstrap intervals, and against MI-greedy on every slide (unadjusted 95% CI resampling studies, unadjusted and Holm-adjusted sign-flip p). Post hoc.

	− feasible design		− MI-greedy on every slide		
Budget	Δ	selection-aware 95% CI	Δ [95% CI]	p	p_H
Reconstruction (PCC): residual policy					
0.5%	−0.092	[−0.132, −0.020]	−0.055 [−0.094, −0.001]	0.057	0.424
1%	−0.057	[−0.087, −0.013]	−0.045 [−0.072, −0.018]	0.008	0.090
2%	−0.025	[−0.047, −0.011]	−0.033 [−0.047, −0.017]	<0.001	0.014
5%	−0.016	[−0.025, −0.008]	−0.016 [−0.025, −0.009]	<0.001	0.003
10%	−0.007	[−0.011, −0.003]	−0.007 [−0.011, −0.003]	<0.001	0.011
20%	−0.002	[−0.004, −0.000]	−0.002 [−0.004, −0.001]	0.010	0.107
Detection (ROI recall): local-variance policy					
2%	+0.008	[−0.002, +0.013]	+0.009 [+0.003, +0.015]	0.017	0.168
5%	+0.006	[−0.004, +0.022]	+0.023 [+0.010, +0.037]	0.005	0.063
10%	+0.017	[−0.011, +0.041]	+0.043 [+0.020, +0.067]	0.003	0.043
20%	+0.026	[−0.018, +0.085]	+0.078 [+0.036, +0.122]	0.003	0.043

G Stage-2 margins and secondary family

Table 12: Detection margins (ROI recall) of the local-variance policy, 22 slides. Δ with unadjusted 95% CI resampling studies; p_H Holm-adjusted over the 18 stage-2 primary margins; MDE_H at 80% power and $\alpha = 0.05/18$.

	local-var. − permuted feedback			local-var. − feasible		local-var. − diversity	
Budget	Δ [95% CI]	p_H	MDE_H	Δ [95% CI]	p_H	Δ [95% CI]	p_H
2%	+0.005 [−0.001, +0.011]	1.000	0.015	+0.008 [+0.002, +0.014]	0.250	+0.001 [−0.004, +0.006]	1.000
5%	+0.017 [+0.002, +0.033]	0.530	0.035	+0.006 [−0.005, +0.016]	1.000	+0.003 [−0.007, +0.012]	1.000
10%	+0.029 [+0.004, +0.056]	0.530	0.066	+0.017 [−0.006, +0.041]	1.000	+0.001 [−0.017, +0.020]	1.000
20%	+0.063 [+0.016, +0.111]	0.294	0.112	+0.026 [−0.018, +0.076]	1.000	+0.012 [−0.021, +0.048]	1.000

Table 13: Reconstruction margins (PCC), 22 slides, 18 studies. Δ: mean per-slide difference with an unadjusted 95% CI resampling studies. p_H: Holm-adjusted within the stage-2 primary or secondary family; p: unadjusted (post hoc).

	residual − feasible (primary)		residual − residual, perm. (secondary)		error-red. − feasible (post hoc)	
Budget	Δ [95% CI]	p_H	Δ [95% CI]	p_H	Δ [95% CI]	p
0.5%	−0.092 [−0.132, −0.054]	0.002	+0.031 [+0.010, +0.057]	0.056	−0.107 [−0.149, −0.067]	<0.001
1%	−0.057 [−0.089, −0.028]	0.010	+0.039 [+0.021, +0.060]	0.002	−0.067 [−0.093, −0.044]	<0.001
2%	−0.025 [−0.041, −0.009]	0.099	+0.030 [+0.014, +0.049]	0.014	−0.024 [−0.039, −0.007]	0.013
5%	−0.016 [−0.025, −0.009]	0.003	+0.009 [+0.001, +0.018]	0.238	−0.010 [−0.017, −0.003]	0.021
10%	−0.007 [−0.011, −0.003]	0.010	+0.001 [−0.002, +0.004]	1.000	−0.001 [−0.006, +0.003]	0.763
20%	−0.002 [−0.004, −0.001]	0.126	−0.001 [−0.003, +0.002]	1.000	+0.001 [−0.002, +0.003]	0.537

Table 14: Stage-2 secondary margins, 22 slides. Unadjusted 95% CIs resampling studies; p_H Holm-adjusted over the secondary family.

Margin	Budget	Δ [95% CI]	p_H
residual − residual, perm. (PCC)	0.5%	+0.031 [+0.010, +0.057]	0.056
residual − hindsight benchmark (PCC)	0.5%	−0.113 [−0.146, −0.084]	<0.001
residual − residual, perm. (PCC)	1%	+0.039 [+0.021, +0.060]	0.002
residual − hindsight benchmark (PCC)	1%	−0.072 [−0.099, −0.051]	<0.001
residual − residual, perm. (PCC)	2%	+0.030 [+0.014, +0.049]	0.014
residual − hindsight benchmark (PCC)	2%	−0.041 [−0.056, −0.029]	<0.001
local-var. − local-var., constant (recall)	2%	+0.004 [−0.001, +0.010]	0.518
local-var. − feasible (PCC)	2%	−0.119 [−0.156, −0.087]	<0.001
residual − residual, perm. (PCC)	5%	+0.009 [+0.001, +0.018]	0.238
residual − hindsight benchmark (PCC)	5%	−0.018 [−0.026, −0.011]	<0.001
local-var. − local-var., constant (recall)	5%	+0.019 [+0.006, +0.032]	0.083
local-var. − feasible (PCC)	5%	−0.146 [−0.178, −0.117]	<0.001
residual − residual, perm. (PCC)	10%	+0.001 [−0.002, +0.004]	1.000
residual − hindsight benchmark (PCC)	10%	−0.008 [−0.012, −0.005]	<0.001
local-var. − local-var., constant (recall)	10%	+0.034 [+0.011, +0.057]	0.076
local-var. − feasible (PCC)	10%	−0.150 [−0.185, −0.120]	<0.001
residual − residual, perm. (PCC)	20%	−0.001 [−0.003, +0.002]	1.000
residual − hindsight benchmark (PCC)	20%	−0.005 [−0.007, −0.003]	0.003
local-var. − local-var., constant (recall)	20%	+0.074 [+0.032, +0.118]	0.038
local-var. − feasible (PCC)	20%	−0.163 [−0.215, −0.123]	<0.001

H Spiked positive control

Table 15: Semi-synthetic control on the 22 slides: residual policy (and its permuted-feedback version) minus the feasible design, by spike amplitude and budget (PCC; unadjusted 95% CIs resampling studies). The registered success criterion was a positive margin with a CI excluding zero at $a_{\text{spike}} = 2$.

a_{spike}	Budget	spiked genes in top 50	residual − feasible	residual, perm. − feasible	residual − residual, perm.
0	5%	0	−0.015 [−0.023, −0.008]	−0.026 [−0.034, −0.018]	+0.010 [+0.002, +0.019]
0	10%	0	−0.007 [−0.011, −0.003]	−0.008 [−0.012, −0.003]	+0.001 [−0.002, +0.004]
1	5%	20	−0.022 [−0.031, −0.013]	−0.030 [−0.038, −0.023]	+0.007 [−0.001, +0.015]
1	10%	20	−0.010 [−0.017, −0.004]	−0.013 [−0.019, −0.007]	+0.003 [−0.002, +0.007]
2	5%	20	−0.021 [−0.030, −0.012]	−0.034 [−0.043, −0.028]	+0.013 [+0.004, +0.023]
2	10%	20	−0.011 [−0.019, −0.004]	−0.018 [−0.026, −0.010]	+0.007 [−0.000, +0.014]

I Stage-3 absolute values, batched acquisition, secondary family, and permutation seeds

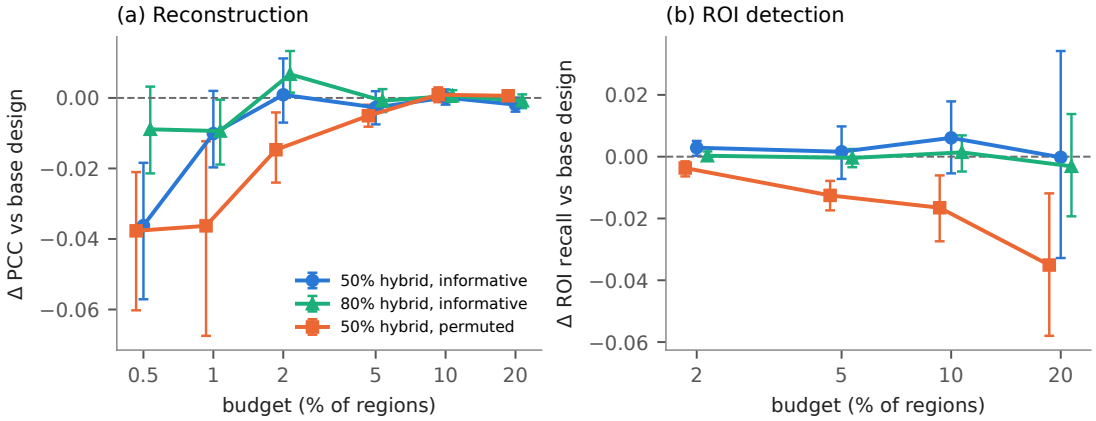


Figure 3: Hybrid minus its base design, 22 slides, mean and unadjusted 95% CI resampling studies. "Informative" hybrids receive the measured values (primary); the permuted series is the 50% hybrid given permuted feedback, averaged over two seeds (descriptive). Base designs as in Table 3.

Table 16: Batched acquisition, stage 3: local-variance policy revealing regions in rounds of 5, 22 slides. "One at a time" is the stage-2 sequential run. Δ with unadjusted 95% CI resampling studies; p_H Holm-adjusted over the 24 stage-3 secondary margins; permuted values averaged over two seeds.

		ROI recall				rounds of 5 − base design		rounds of 5 − permuted	
Budget	base design	base	one at a time	rounds of 5	rounds of 5, perm.	Δ [95% CI]	p_H	Δ [95% CI]	p_H
10%	variance-greedy	0.127	0.137	0.150	0.100	+0.023 [−0.000, +0.046]	0.749	+0.050 [+0.022, +0.075]	0.113
20%	one-shot	0.252	0.278	0.288	0.204	+0.035 [−0.017, +0.095]	1.000	+0.084 [+0.025, +0.141]	0.240

Table 17: Stage-3 mean scores over 22 slides: the base design, the hybrids with informative and permuted feedback (two seeds averaged), and the feedback policy run alone for the whole budget (residual policy for reconstruction, local-variance for detection; stage-2 runs). Base designs as in Table 3.

		50% hybrid		80% hybrid		
Budget	base design	informative	permuted	informative	permuted	feedback policy alone
Reconstruction (PCC)						
0.5%	0.449	0.413	0.412	0.441	0.437	0.357
1%	0.534	0.524	0.498	0.525	0.517	0.477
2%	0.599	0.600	0.584	0.605	0.599	0.566
5%	0.659	0.656	0.654	0.658	0.657	0.643
10%	0.685	0.685	0.686	0.686	0.687	0.678
20%	0.707	0.705	0.708	0.706	0.708	0.705
Detection (ROI recall)						
2%	0.023	0.026	0.019	0.024	0.022	0.027
5%	0.064	0.065	0.051	0.063	0.060	0.070
10%	0.127	0.133	0.110	0.128	0.121	0.137
20%	0.252	0.252	0.217	0.249	0.232	0.278

Table 18: Stage-3 secondary margins, 22 slides. Unadjusted 95% CIs resampling studies; p_H Holm-adjusted over the 24 secondary margins. Permuted values are averaged over two seeds.

Margin	Budget	Δ [95% CI]	p_H
reconstruction, 50% hybrid − permuted	0.5%	+0.0015 [−0.0152, +0.0155]	1.000
reconstruction, 80% hybrid − permuted	0.5%	+0.0040 [−0.0012, +0.0100]	1.000
reconstruction, 50% hybrid − permuted	1%	+0.0262 [+0.0065, +0.0540]	0.209
reconstruction, 80% hybrid − permuted	1%	+0.0078 [−0.0002, +0.0161]	0.749
reconstruction, 50% hybrid − permuted	2%	+0.0156 [+0.0074, +0.0254]	0.027
detection, 50% hybrid − permuted	2%	+0.0066 [+0.0039, +0.0093]	0.004
reconstruction, 80% hybrid − permuted	2%	+0.0067 [+0.0040, +0.0094]	0.016
detection, 80% hybrid − permuted	2%	+0.0016 [+0.0002, +0.0028]	0.477
reconstruction, 50% hybrid − permuted	5%	+0.0024 [−0.0013, +0.0062]	1.000
detection, 50% hybrid − permuted	5%	+0.0141 [+0.0059, +0.0215]	0.113
reconstruction, 80% hybrid − permuted	5%	+0.0012 [−0.0012, +0.0039]	1.000
detection, 80% hybrid − permuted	5%	+0.0037 [+0.0011, +0.0059]	0.277
reconstruction, 50% hybrid − permuted	10%	−0.0008 [−0.0027, +0.0010]	1.000
detection, 50% hybrid − permuted	10%	+0.0227 [+0.0077, +0.0352]	0.209
reconstruction, 80% hybrid − permuted	10%	−0.0018 [−0.0031, −0.0006]	0.124
detection, 80% hybrid − permuted	10%	+0.0074 [−0.0004, +0.0139]	0.749
reconstruction, 50% hybrid − permuted	20%	−0.0025 [−0.0044, −0.0006]	0.277
detection, 50% hybrid − permuted	20%	+0.0349 [+0.0097, +0.0570]	0.277
reconstruction, 80% hybrid − permuted	20%	−0.0019 [−0.0039, −0.0002]	0.477
detection, 80% hybrid − permuted	20%	+0.0169 [+0.0041, +0.0291]	0.277
rounds of 5: local-variance − variance-greedy	10%	+0.0233 [−0.0001, +0.0463]	0.749
rounds of 5: local-variance − permuted	10%	+0.0497 [+0.0216, +0.0747]	0.113
rounds of 5: local-variance − one-shot	20%	+0.0352 [−0.0168, +0.0952]	1.000
rounds of 5: local-variance − permuted	20%	+0.0839 [+0.0247, +0.1405]	0.240

Table 19: Stage-2 feedback ablations repeated over permutation seeds, 22 slides (descriptive). Seed 2021 is the registered stage-2 run. SD is across the seed means; the seed-averaged margin uses the mean of the permuted runs, with an unadjusted 95% CI resampling studies.

	mean margin by permutation seed						
Budget	2021 (stage 2)	1	2	3	4	SD	seed-averaged Δ [95% CI]
Reconstruction (PCC): residual − permuted							
0.5%	+0.031	+0.024	+0.016	–	–	0.007	+0.023 [+0.008, +0.042]
1%	+0.039	+0.040	+0.030	–	–	0.006	+0.036 [+0.020, +0.055]
2%	+0.030	+0.023	+0.025	–	–	0.004	+0.026 [+0.013, +0.041]
5%	+0.009	+0.010	+0.012	–	–	0.002	+0.010 [+0.002, +0.019]
10%	+0.001	0.000	+0.003	–	–	0.002	+0.001 [−0.002, +0.005]
20%	−0.001	−0.001	+0.001	–	–	0.001	0.000 [−0.002, +0.001]
Detection (ROI recall): local-variance − permuted							
2%	+0.005	+0.003	+0.003	+0.006	+0.007	0.002	+0.005 [−0.000, +0.010]
5%	+0.017	+0.011	+0.016	+0.020	+0.022	0.004	+0.017 [+0.005, +0.030]
10%	+0.029	+0.025	+0.034	+0.035	+0.042	0.006	+0.033 [+0.012, +0.056]
20%	+0.063	+0.075	+0.083	+0.060	+0.090	0.013	+0.074 [+0.031, +0.118]

J Stage-4 secondary, tile-scale, and headroom results

Table 20 gives the stage-4 secondary family. The residual policy's and the reconstruction hybrid's constant-feedback rows compare with a version that selects in index order (Section 3.6) and are not a test of what

the values add. Table 21 gives the tile-scale families, Table 22 the ground-truth greedy bound, and Table 23 the post hoc checks of the tuned policy.

Constant feedback at the tuned kernel width. Under constant feedback the local-variance term should be zero everywhere, which would make the constant version identical for every exploration weight and kernel width, so that the stage-2 constant run would serve as the control for every tuned setting. The policy, however, divides kernel-weighted sums by the kernel sum clipped below at 10^{-12}. A candidate more than about 7.4 kernel widths from every profiled region then receives a spurious variance even under constant values. On three synthetic slides, the constant-feedback selections were identical across the four exploration weights and the widths 0.1 and 0.2, but differed at width 0.05 from the second pick onward, the floor acting only in the first few picks. The constant control in Table 23 therefore uses the width-0.1 run and is approximate for the tuned settings; the exact control requires running the width-0.05 settings with constant feedback.

Table 20: Stage-4 secondary margins on the common evaluation set, 22 slides. Δ with unadjusted 95% CI resampling studies; p_H Holm-adjusted over the 30 secondary margins; MDE_H at 80% power and $\alpha = 0.05/30$.

Margin	Budget	Δ [95% CI]	p_H	MDE_H
Reconstruction (held-out PCC; MSE row: feasible − residual, positive favours residual)				
feasible − residual	0.5%	−0.265 [−0.454, −0.126]	0.008	0.623
feasible − residual	1%	−0.124 [−0.230, −0.055]	0.004	0.348
feasible − residual	2%	−0.060 [−0.099, −0.023]	0.092	0.122
feasible − residual	5%	−0.034 [−0.046, −0.020]	0.018	0.032
feasible − residual	10%	−0.012 [−0.021, −0.002]	0.222	0.017
feasible − residual	20%	+0.007 [+0.001, +0.013]	0.222	0.014
residual − constant feedback	0.5%	+0.036 [−0.005, +0.078]	0.531	0.111
residual − constant feedback	1%	+0.067 [+0.030, +0.105]	0.057	0.094
residual − constant feedback	2%	+0.074 [+0.032, +0.119]	0.045	0.095
residual − constant feedback	5%	+0.068 [+0.020, +0.122]	0.063	0.093
residual − constant feedback	10%	+0.063 [+0.013, +0.119]	0.092	0.074
residual − constant feedback	20%	+0.049 [+0.010, +0.096]	0.079	0.059
50% reconstruction hybrid − constant feedback	0.5%	+0.033 [+0.011, +0.060]	0.132	0.054
50% reconstruction hybrid − constant feedback	1%	+0.056 [+0.033, +0.083]	0.004	0.054
50% reconstruction hybrid − constant feedback	2%	+0.039 [+0.026, +0.052]	<0.001	0.032
50% reconstruction hybrid − constant feedback	5%	+0.016 [+0.008, +0.024]	0.004	0.016
50% reconstruction hybrid − constant feedback	10%	+0.009 [+0.005, +0.013]	0.042	0.013
50% reconstruction hybrid − constant feedback	20%	+0.006 [+0.003, +0.009]	0.030	0.008
Detection (ROI recall)				
local-variance − constant feedback	2%	+0.010 [+0.002, +0.018]	0.187	0.018
local-variance − constant feedback	5%	+0.022 [+0.007, +0.039]	0.097	0.037
local-variance − constant feedback	10%	+0.041 [+0.019, +0.067]	0.057	0.057
local-variance − constant feedback	20%	+0.096 [+0.049, +0.146]	0.012	0.106
50% detection hybrid − variance-greedy	2%	+0.002 [−0.002, +0.006]	1.000	0.012
50% detection hybrid − variance-greedy	5%	+0.005 [−0.004, +0.015]	1.000	0.025
50% detection hybrid − variance-greedy	10%	+0.013 [−0.002, +0.026]	0.531	0.040
50% detection hybrid − one-shot	20%	−0.006 [−0.038, +0.028]	1.000	0.075
50% detection hybrid − constant feedback	2%	+0.005 [+0.002, +0.009]	0.187	0.009
50% detection hybrid − constant feedback	5%	+0.020 [+0.012, +0.027]	0.007	0.020
50% detection hybrid − constant feedback	10%	+0.036 [+0.020, +0.052]	0.022	0.043
50% detection hybrid − constant feedback	20%	+0.037 [+0.017, +0.057]	0.063	0.057

Table 21: Stage-4 margins with 300 μm tiles, 22 slides. Reconstruction margins in held-out tile PCC, detection margins in tile-ROI recall. Δ with unadjusted 95% CI resampling studies; p_H Holm-adjusted within each family of 9; MDE_H at 80% power and $\alpha = 0.05/9$.

Margin	Budget	Δ [95% CI]	p_H	MDE_H
Primary (9 margins)				
residual − feasible	12 tiles	-0.006 $[-0.057, +0.046]$	1.000	0.117
local-variance − feasible	12 tiles	$+0.012$ $[-0.003, +0.024]$	0.682	0.038
local-variance, 2 rounds − feasible	12 tiles	$+0.004$ $[-0.010, +0.016]$	1.000	0.036
residual − feasible	24 tiles	$+0.003$ $[-0.036, +0.048]$	1.000	0.083
local-variance − feasible	24 tiles	$+0.009$ $[-0.013, +0.026]$	1.000	0.054
local-variance, 2 rounds − feasible	24 tiles	-0.022 $[-0.042, -0.005]$	0.203	0.044
residual − feasible	48 tiles	-0.018 $[-0.035, 0.000]$	0.477	0.038
local-variance − feasible	48 tiles	$+0.018$ $[-0.015, +0.049]$	1.000	0.083
local-variance, 2 rounds − feasible	48 tiles	-0.059 $[-0.093, -0.027]$	0.015	0.077
Secondary (9 margins)				
residual − constant feedback	12 tiles	$+0.183$ $[+0.138, +0.231]$	<0.001	0.106
local-variance − constant feedback	12 tiles	$+0.002$ $[-0.011, +0.013]$	1.000	0.031
local-variance, 4 rounds − feasible	12 tiles	$+0.007$ $[-0.008, +0.021]$	1.000	0.034
residual − constant feedback	24 tiles	$+0.273$ $[+0.218, +0.329]$	<0.001	0.132
local-variance − constant feedback	24 tiles	$+0.023$ $[+0.002, +0.042]$	0.245	0.054
local-variance, 4 rounds − feasible	24 tiles	-0.008 $[-0.027, +0.012]$	1.000	0.043
residual − constant feedback	48 tiles	$+0.261$ $[+0.199, +0.327]$	<0.001	0.134
local-variance − constant feedback	48 tiles	$+0.045$ $[+0.009, +0.074]$	0.154	0.094
local-variance, 4 rounds − feasible	48 tiles	-0.028 $[-0.059, +0.001]$	0.347	0.065

Table 22: Ground-truth greedy bound (held-out PCC) against the best fixed design and the residual policy, one slide per tissue (descriptive). The bound selects on its own evaluation score and overstates what a policy could reach.

Slide	Budget	greedy bound	best fixed design	PCC	residual	bound − best fixed
TENX174 (prostate)	0.5%	0.769	k-means	0.621	0.373	+0.148
TENX174 (prostate)	1%	0.794	MI-greedy	0.721	0.550	+0.073
TENX174 (prostate)	2%	0.845	MI-greedy	0.801	0.765	+0.044
TENX173 (kidney)	0.5%	0.284	k-means	0.258	0.161	+0.026
TENX173 (kidney)	1%	0.349	k-means	0.242	0.186	+0.107
TENX173 (kidney)	2%	0.395	k-means	0.273	0.260	+0.122
TENX171 (lung)	0.5%	0.537	MI-greedy	0.376	0.276	+0.161
TENX171 (lung)	1%	0.585	MI-greedy	0.457	0.420	+0.129
TENX171 (lung)	2%	0.622	MI-greedy	0.548	0.491	+0.075
TENX155 (colon)	0.5%	0.573	k-means	0.407	0.271	+0.166
TENX155 (colon)	1%	0.603	k-means	0.501	0.451	+0.102
TENX155 (colon)	2%	0.642	MI-greedy	0.535	0.503	+0.107

Table 23: Post hoc checks of the tuned local-variance policy (recall, 22 slides). Margins of the tuned policy over its constant-feedback version (width-0.1 run; approximate, see text) and over the diversity sampler, which a feasible pool including it chose for every study at every budget; unadjusted 95% CIs resampling studies, Holm over the four budgets. Selection-aware intervals repeat both leave-one-study-out choices in every bootstrap replicate.

Comparison	2%	5%	10%	20%
− constant feedback (width 0.1, approximate), Δ [95% CI]	+0.012 [+0.006, +0.019]	+0.036 [+0.021, +0.052]	+0.066 [+0.036, +0.098]	+0.112 [+0.062, +0.164]
p_H (4 budgets)	0.003	0.002	0.002	0.002
− diversity sampler (feasible pool + diversity), Δ [95% CI]	+0.009 [+0.002, +0.015]	+0.020 [+0.005, +0.036]	+0.033 [+0.004, +0.068]	+0.050 [+0.002, +0.105]
p_H (4 budgets)	0.104	0.104	0.104	0.104
− feasible (registered), selection-aware 95% CI	[+0.004, +0.020]	[+0.005, +0.042]	[+0.007, +0.085]	[−0.001, +0.142]
p_H over all 25 stage-4 primary margins	0.006	0.108	0.088	0.900
− feasible with diversity sampler, selection-aware 95% CI	[+0.001, +0.019]	[−0.001, +0.039]	[−0.002, +0.070]	[−0.001, +0.111]

K Gene-set sensitivity

Table 24: Stage-1 local-variance minus the hindsight benchmark of the coverage designs, reconstruction (PCC), under three gene sets, 22 slides, unadjusted 95% CIs resampling studies (secondary).

Budget	per-slide top-50 HVG	reference-subset top-50 HVG	all filtered genes
2%	−0.136 [−0.171, −0.106]	−0.134 [−0.168, −0.103]	−0.032 [−0.047, −0.021]
5%	−0.148 [−0.180, −0.119]	−0.148 [−0.182, −0.118]	−0.052 [−0.068, −0.040]
10%	−0.152 [−0.186, −0.122]	−0.153 [−0.189, −0.122]	−0.068 [−0.087, −0.052]
20%	−0.165 [−0.217, −0.125]	−0.166 [−0.217, −0.126]	−0.079 [−0.101, −0.061]

L Platform and tissue splits

The platform split is exploratory and the per-tissue means are descriptive; both use stage-1 margins.

Table 25: Selected stage-1 margins by platform (unadjusted study-level sign-flip p) and by tissue (mean).

	HD (n=7, 5 cl.)	Visium (n=15, 13 cl.)	prostate (n=6)	kidney (n=4)	lung (n=6)	colon (n=6)
Recon., error-red. (1%)	−0.113 (0.062)	−0.068 (<0.001)	−0.078	−0.085	−0.081	−0.088
Recon., local-var. (10%)	−0.103 (0.062)	−0.174 (<0.001)	−0.115	−0.171	−0.141	−0.185
Detect., local-var. (10%)	+0.048 (0.062)	+0.008 (0.426)	−0.001	+0.022	+0.036	+0.027
Detect., local-var. (20%)	+0.099 (0.062)	+0.015 (0.469)	+0.015	+0.024	+0.052	+0.070
Detect., rounds of 5 (10%)	+0.049 (0.250)	+0.026 (0.044)	+0.016	+0.012	+0.046	+0.053

M Native SOFisher run

We ran SOFisher from the authors' repository on its bundled mouse cortex data for 5 million steps (seed 222) with the repository's cortex script. The only change was checkpoint and resume support, so the run could continue after interruptions. Figure 4 shows the evaluation reward, which counts captured target regions. Its median was −238 over the first 5% of training and +147 over the last 10% (best 514). Rare evaluation episodes have rewards near -1.7×10^5, so the figure shows rolling medians.

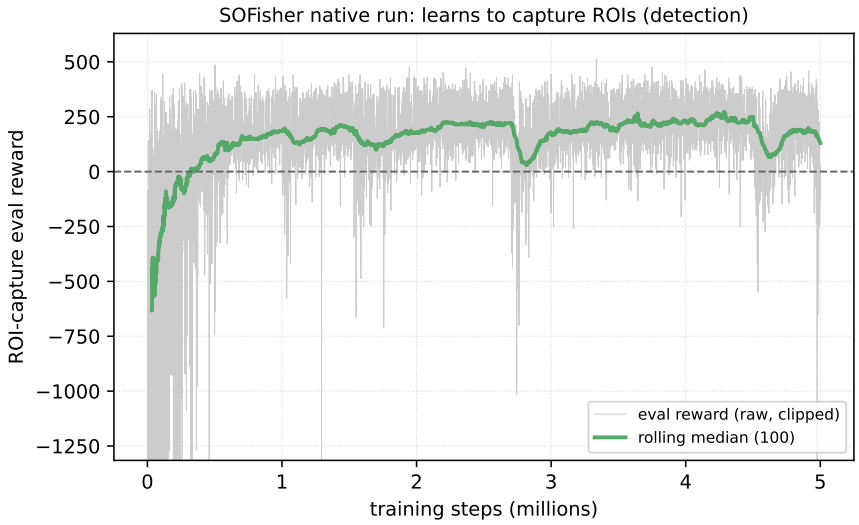


Figure 4: SOFisher evaluation reward during training (rolling median), native run.

N Post hoc robustness checks

Three checks on existing results (post hoc, descriptive). Random selection of n of N regions captures on average a fraction n/N of any fixed ROI set; Table 26 gives each design's recall above this expectation. Table 27 sets the registered bootstrap intervals beside intervals from inverting the exact sign-flip test; the two disagree about excluding zero for three of 38 margins, including the feedback margins at 5% and 10%. Table 28 repeats the primary analyses without TENX174, the slide used to set the imputer's hyperparameters; no conclusion changes.

Table 26: Detection recall minus the recall expected of random selection, 22 slides; 95% CI from inverting the study-level sign-flip test.

	expected recall	recall minus expected random recall, Δ [95% CI]			
Budget	of random selection	local-variance	feasible design	diversity sampler	MI-greedy
2%	0.020	+0.007 [+0.000, +0.013]	−0.002 [−0.005, +0.002]	+0.006 [+0.001, +0.012]	−0.002 [−0.005, +0.000]
5%	0.050	+0.020 [+0.005, +0.034]	+0.014 [+0.005, +0.024]	+0.017 [+0.005, +0.032]	−0.004 [−0.008, +0.000]
10%	0.100	+0.037 [+0.011, +0.061]	+0.020 [−0.000, +0.045]	+0.036 [+0.016, +0.060]	−0.006 [−0.011, −0.002]
20%	0.200	+0.078 [+0.029, +0.125]	+0.052 [+0.007, +0.104]	+0.066 [+0.036, +0.103]	0.000 [−0.008, +0.010]

Table 27: Registered primary margins with the registered bootstrap interval and the sign-flip inversion interval.

Margin	Budget	Δ [registered bootstrap 95% CI]	sign-flip inversion 95% CI
Stage 2 primary family			
residual − feasible (PCC)	0.5%	-0.092 $[-0.132, -0.054]$	$[-0.135, -0.049]$
residual − feasible (PCC)	1%	-0.057 $[-0.089, -0.028]$	$[-0.089, -0.026]$
residual − feasible (PCC)	2%	-0.025 $[-0.040, -0.009]$	$[-0.042, -0.007]$
residual − feasible (PCC)	5%	-0.016 $[-0.025, -0.009]$	$[-0.025, -0.007]$
residual − feasible (PCC)	10%	-0.007 $[-0.011, -0.003]$	$[-0.011, -0.003]$
residual − feasible (PCC)	20%	-0.002 $[-0.004, -0.001]$	$[-0.004, -0.001]$
local-variance − permuted (recall)	2%	$+0.005$ $[-0.001, +0.011]$	$[-0.002, +0.012]$
local-variance − feasible (recall)	2%	$+0.008$ $[+0.002, +0.014]$	$[+0.001, +0.015]$
local-variance − diversity (recall)	2%	$+0.001$ $[-0.004, +0.006]$	$[-0.005, +0.006]$
local-variance − permuted (recall)	5%	$+0.017$ $[+0.002, +0.033]$	$[-0.001, +0.034]$
local-variance − feasible (recall)	5%	$+0.006$ $[-0.005, +0.016]$	$[-0.006, +0.017]$
local-variance − diversity (recall)	5%	$+0.003$ $[-0.007, +0.012]$	$[-0.009, +0.013]$
local-variance − permuted (recall)	10%	$+0.030$ $[+0.004, +0.056]$	$[-0.000, +0.058]$
local-variance − feasible (recall)	10%	$+0.017$ $[-0.007, +0.041]$	$[-0.010, +0.042]$
local-variance − diversity (recall)	10%	$+0.001$ $[-0.017, +0.020]$	$[-0.020, +0.021]$
local-variance − permuted (recall)	20%	$+0.063$ $[+0.016, +0.111]$	$[+0.008, +0.114]$
local-variance − feasible (recall)	20%	$+0.026$ $[-0.018, +0.076]$	$[-0.025, +0.076]$
local-variance − diversity (recall)	20%	$+0.012$ $[-0.021, +0.048]$	$[-0.025, +0.049]$
Stage 3 primary family			
reconstruction 50% hybrid − k-means	0.5%	-0.036 $[-0.057, -0.018]$	$[-0.059, -0.015]$
reconstruction 80% hybrid − k-means	0.5%	-0.009 $[-0.021, +0.003]$	$[-0.023, +0.005]$
reconstruction 50% hybrid − k-means	1%	-0.010 $[-0.020, +0.002]$	$[-0.021, +0.003]$
reconstruction 80% hybrid − k-means	1%	-0.009 $[-0.019, -0.001]$	$[-0.020, +0.001]$
reconstruction 50% hybrid − MI-greedy	2%	$+0.001$ $[-0.007, +0.011]$	$[-0.008, +0.012]$
reconstruction 80% hybrid − MI-greedy	2%	$+0.007$ $[+0.002, +0.013]$	$[+0.001, +0.013]$
reconstruction 50% hybrid − MI-greedy	5%	-0.003 $[-0.007, +0.002]$	$[-0.008, +0.003]$
reconstruction 80% hybrid − MI-greedy	5%	-0.001 $[-0.004, +0.002]$	$[-0.004, +0.003]$
reconstruction 50% hybrid − MI-greedy	10%	0.000 $[-0.002, +0.002]$	$[-0.002, +0.003]$
reconstruction 80% hybrid − MI-greedy	10%	$+0.001$ $[-0.001, +0.002]$	$[-0.001, +0.002]$
reconstruction 50% hybrid − MI-greedy	20%	-0.002 $[-0.004, +0.000]$	$[-0.004, +0.000]$
reconstruction 80% hybrid − MI-greedy	20%	-0.001 $[-0.003, +0.001]$	$[-0.003, +0.001]$
detection 50% hybrid − variance-greedy	2%	$+0.003$ $[+0.000, +0.005]$	$[+0.000, +0.005]$
detection 80% hybrid − variance-greedy	2%	0.000 $[-0.001, +0.002]$	$[-0.001, +0.002]$
detection 50% hybrid − variance-greedy	5%	$+0.002$ $[-0.007, +0.010]$	$[-0.008, +0.011]$
detection 80% hybrid − variance-greedy	5%	0.000 $[-0.003, +0.002]$	$[-0.004, +0.003]$
detection 50% hybrid − variance-greedy	10%	$+0.006$ $[-0.005, +0.018]$	$[-0.007, +0.018]$
detection 80% hybrid − variance-greedy	10%	$+0.001$ $[-0.005, +0.007]$	$[-0.006, +0.007]$
detection 50% hybrid − one-shot	20%	0.000 $[-0.033, +0.034]$	$[-0.038, +0.036]$
detection 80% hybrid − one-shot	20%	-0.003 $[-0.019, +0.014]$	$[-0.023, +0.015]$

Table 28: Registered primary margins with and without the development slide TENX174; p_H Holm-adjusted within each family over 17 studies.

		all 22 slides	without TENX174 (21 slides, 17 studies)	
Margin	Budget	Δ	Δ [95% CI]	p_H
Stage 2 primary family				
residual − feasible (PCC)	0.5%	−0.092	−0.087 [−0.128, −0.049]	0.005
residual − feasible (PCC)	1%	−0.057	−0.055 [−0.088, −0.026]	0.018
residual − feasible (PCC)	2%	−0.025	−0.024 [−0.041, −0.008]	0.134
residual − feasible (PCC)	5%	−0.016	−0.017 [−0.026, −0.009]	0.003
residual − feasible (PCC)	10%	−0.007	−0.007 [−0.011, −0.004]	0.013
residual − feasible (PCC)	20%	−0.002	−0.002 [−0.004, −0.001]	0.113
local-variance − permuted (recall)	2%	+0.005	+0.005 [−0.001, +0.012]	1.000
local-variance − feasible (recall)	2%	+0.008	+0.007 [+0.001, +0.012]	0.370
local-variance − diversity (recall)	2%	+0.001	+0.001 [−0.004, +0.006]	1.000
local-variance − permuted (recall)	5%	+0.017	+0.016 [+0.001, +0.033]	0.805
local-variance − feasible (recall)	5%	+0.006	+0.006 [−0.005, +0.017]	1.000
local-variance − diversity (recall)	5%	+0.003	+0.004 [−0.006, +0.014]	1.000
local-variance − permuted (recall)	10%	+0.030	+0.028 [+0.002, +0.056]	0.769
local-variance − feasible (recall)	10%	+0.017	+0.016 [−0.009, +0.042]	1.000
local-variance − diversity (recall)	10%	+0.001	+0.002 [−0.018, +0.022]	1.000
local-variance − permuted (recall)	20%	+0.063	+0.061 [+0.010, +0.112]	0.467
local-variance − feasible (recall)	20%	+0.026	+0.043 [−0.003, +0.093]	0.899
local-variance − diversity (recall)	20%	+0.012	+0.013 [−0.022, +0.053]	1.000
Stage 3 primary family				
reconstruction 50% hybrid − k-means	0.5%	−0.036	−0.037 [−0.059, −0.018]	0.011
reconstruction 80% hybrid − k-means	0.5%	−0.009	−0.009 [−0.022, +0.004]	1.000
reconstruction 50% hybrid − k-means	1%	−0.010	−0.009 [−0.020, +0.003]	1.000
reconstruction 80% hybrid − k-means	1%	−0.009	−0.011 [−0.020, −0.003]	0.503
reconstruction 50% hybrid − MI-greedy	2%	+0.001	+0.001 [−0.007, +0.012]	1.000
reconstruction 80% hybrid − MI-greedy	2%	+0.007	+0.007 [+0.002, +0.014]	0.327
reconstruction 50% hybrid − MI-greedy	5%	−0.003	−0.003 [−0.008, +0.002]	1.000
reconstruction 80% hybrid − MI-greedy	5%	−0.001	−0.001 [−0.004, +0.003]	1.000
reconstruction 50% hybrid − MI-greedy	10%	0.000	0.000 [−0.002, +0.002]	1.000
reconstruction 80% hybrid − MI-greedy	10%	+0.001	+0.001 [−0.001, +0.002]	1.000
reconstruction 50% hybrid − MI-greedy	20%	−0.002	−0.002 [−0.004, +0.000]	1.000
reconstruction 80% hybrid − MI-greedy	20%	−0.001	−0.001 [−0.003, +0.001]	1.000
detection 50% hybrid − variance-greedy	2%	+0.003	+0.002 [−0.000, +0.005]	1.000
detection 80% hybrid − variance-greedy	2%	0.000	0.000 [−0.001, +0.002]	1.000
detection 50% hybrid − variance-greedy	5%	+0.002	+0.002 [−0.007, +0.010]	1.000
detection 80% hybrid − variance-greedy	5%	0.000	0.000 [−0.004, +0.003]	1.000
detection 50% hybrid − variance-greedy	10%	+0.006	+0.006 [−0.006, +0.018]	1.000
detection 80% hybrid − variance-greedy	10%	+0.001	+0.002 [−0.005, +0.008]	1.000
detection 50% hybrid − one-shot	20%	0.000	+0.005 [−0.026, +0.040]	1.000
detection 80% hybrid − one-shot	20%	−0.003	−0.001 [−0.017, +0.017]	1.000